Evaluate

Variance commentary with Claude in 5 steps

From a variance table to reviewed commentary, without inventing a single reason.

1. Prepare the data, not the story
2. Give it context it can't guess
3. Ask for drivers, not descriptions
4. Force it to flag what it doesn't know
5. Review it like a junior analyst's draft

Swipe for the 5 steps

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1

Step 1 of 5

Prepare the data, not the story

Export actuals, budget and prior year with the variance already calculated.

Prompt to copy — Paste the table with the variance already calculated.

```
Here is the variance table. Variances are
already calculated, do not recalculate them.

[PASTE TABLE: line item | actual | budget |
variance € | variance % | prior year]

Additional notes from the business:
[PASTE OR "none"]
```

The spreadsheet does the maths.
The AI does the words.

2

Step 2 of 5

Give it context it can't guess

Materiality threshold, known one-offs, last month's commentary.

Prompt to copy Paste once at the start of the conversation.

```
You are helping a finance team draft monthly
variance commentary for [COMPANY TYPE, e.g. a mid-
sized insurer].

Context:
- Reporting period: [MONTH YEAR]
- Comparison: actuals vs budget and vs prior year
- Materiality threshold: comment only on variances
above [€ AMOUNT] or [X]%
- Known one-off items this month: [LIST, or "none"]
- Audience: [CFO / management committee / board]

Rules:
…
```

No context in, generic sentences out.

3

Step 3 of 5

Ask for drivers, not descriptions

“Revenue is up 8%” is a description. “Revenue is up 8%, driven by price increases in Q3” is commentary.

Prompt to copy — The core prompt.

```
For each line item above the materiality threshold,
write one or two sentences of commentary.

Each sentence must:
1. State the variance (direction and size).
2. Name the driver (price, volume, timing, one-off,
mix, FX or other).
3. Say whether it is expected to continue next
month, if the notes tell you.

Format: line item in bold, then the commentary.
Mark any variance without a clear driver in the
notes with [CHECK].
```

Tell it which one you want.

4

Step 4 of 5

Force it to flag what it doesn't know

Every variance it can't explain from your notes gets marked [CHECK].

Add this line to your prompt

```
If you cannot explain a variance from the information provided, write [CHECK] instead of guessing.
```

A blank beats an invented reason.

5

Step 5 of 5

Review it like a junior's draft

Check every number against the source before it leaves your desk.

Prompt to copy Use before review, it catches weak spots.

```
Review the commentary you wrote as a sceptical
CFO would.

List:
1. Any sentence that describes a variance
without explaining it.
2. Any claim not supported by the data or notes
I provided.
3. The three questions the CFO is most likely
to ask.
Do not rewrite the commentary, just list the
issues.
```

The AI writes the first draft. You own the final one.

Before you start

One rule before you start

Never paste client names, account numbers or restricted data. Aggregate first, or use an approved enterprise setup.

Free resource

Get the 6 prompts

Free. The link is in the post.

No signup.

